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Nupe religion

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The mood of the mourners, which must be kept up for eight days, is rigidly conventionalized, though the convention is maintained with varying success. Also, it differs for the sexes. The men keep a severe, dignified and calm countenance; there must be no irrelevant chatting, only subdued talk, one topic alone being allowed, the dead person, his achievements and qualities. But the rule is often broken; on one such occasion I heard the mourners discuss farming prospects and taxes (if in whispers), and one man, whom I had some time previously presented with a watch, thought nothing of asking my wife, in the middle of the mourning, to wind up his watch for him. However, as soon as a new visitor enters, everyone at once puts on the rigid look that passes for a show of grief. Nor is the violent mourning of the women uninterrupted; now and again they may cease their sobbing and wailing and rest for a while. Female relatives who come from distant places will join in the wailing for one day and afterwards stay as ordinary guests. They, too, sit together and talk in whispers, but do not omit their more prosaic duties; for young mothers come with their babies, who must be fed and looked after, and others will help with the work in the house.

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For eight days the relatives of the deceased may not wash, dress their hair or change their clothes. None of the older people may leave the house, and the women not even their huts (save for calls of nature). The men observe this rule for four days only, so that afterwards they may help with the preparations for the Eight Days' feast. But even before that household work has been going on all the time, being shouldered mainly by the younger folk. The young men will continue to go to the farms or to the market, joining the mourners in the evening, while girls and young women look after the house. These are least affected by the duties of mourning; when, the day after the burial, they level

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the floor over the grave, they exhibit no signs of grief, but laugh and joke freely. This, the Nupe will tell you, is quite in order: for the workers are always in-laws and 'joking relations' of the deceased (daughters-in-law or the wives of younger brothers), and are hence exempt from mourning.

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